

guns were more effective than mortars, mostly 8- and 10-in (200- and 250-mm) giants, which could lob shells behind enemy parapets.

Siege artillery made for spectacular nocturnal fireworks. In some Union forts at Petersburg, watching the display became an evening ritual. "Sometimes more than twenty shells would be in the air at the same time, looking like twinkling stars shooting and plunging madly," recalled one observer at Fort Haskell. "Then a wide, sudden sheet of flame would terminate its flight, and woe to him or them who came within its deadly circle."



The "Dictator"

Weighing 17,000lb (7,711kg) and known as the "Dictator," this 13-in (330-mm) siege mortar could fire 200-lb (90-kg) shells more than two miles (3.2 km). It was used at Petersburg for two months.